savings in the city and prospects of dramatic upward mobility whereby cleaners could rise up to start their own restaurants.

Chennai, Mysore and Bangalore were important destinations for the Udupi migrants, but it was Mumbai that would capture the imagination for the next century. Matunga in Mumbai became a veritable bastion of south Indian migrants, and Udupi restaurants with Ramanayaks, Café Madras and several others established in the 1930s and 40s. Land reforms in the 1970s stimulated greater migration of Bunts, a dominant peasant caste of Udupi, who took on the mantle from the Brahmins to run the bulk of Udupi restaurants, often taking over old Irani restaurants. Vegard Iversen, an economist with an anthropological streak, studied the evolution of the Udupi migration and restaurant phenomenon and noted the strength of caste networks in sustaining restaurant proliferation and food practices and its interaction with urban cosmopolitanism.[15] Only in big cities did employment opportunities in Udupi restaurants significantly widen to accommodate other castes and religions. In Mumbai, night schools for restaurant staff were a prominent feature in the initial years, and working conditions improved substantially after the labour rights movements of the 1950s and ’1960s championed by George Fernandes, himself a product of the coastal Karnataka migration wave. The invasion of north Indian and Chinese dishes into the menus in the closing decades of the 20th century helped diminish the notions of purity associated with traditional vegetarian south Indian food. In smaller towns, and even in Bangalore to some extent, orthodoxy in menus and the workforce continued to prevail.

The common factor across locations was the high rate of return migration. Working outside the district was a rite of working life, but retirement took most migrants back home. Until now, Udupi’s economy continues to be sustained by migrants’ remittances, much of which goes towards temple trusts. These remittances clash with remittances from many Muslim emigrants working in the Gulf countries, leading to a communal and caste-based display of wealth and violence. However, despite persistent mass outmigration and remittance related woes, Udupi is not the characteristic basket case of underdevelopment. Instead, it outperforms all